

THE DAILY BRIEF

JULY 21, 2026

AI & TECH

Latest in artificial intelligence, models, and technology

Anthropic's \$1.5 Billion Copyright Settlement Gets Final Approval — But the Fight Isn't Over. A federal court has granted final approval to Anthropic's landmark \$1.5 billion settlement with thousands of authors whose works were used to train Claude. The deal is the largest ever reached between an AI company and creative rights holders, and it sets an important precedent. But here's the catch: the settlement resolves this specific case, not the broader legal question of whether training on copyrighted material is itself infringement. Anthropic and every other AI company still face a cascade of similar lawsuits. The underlying legal theory — that scraping the open web to train commercial AI models requires a license — has not been answered. This settlement is a truce on one battlefield, not the end of the war. (TechCrunch)

Google Is Building a New AI Chip to Make Gemini Run Faster and Cheaper. Alphabet is developing a fresh AI accelerator chip internally, designed from the ground up to run Gemini more efficiently than current hardware allows. The project signals Google's continued push to own more of its AI infrastructure stack — reducing reliance on Nvidia while competing with Apple's custom silicon ambitions. If the chip delivers meaningful efficiency gains, it could sharply lower the cost-per-query for Gemini API access, which has been a friction point vs. OpenAI's pricing. This is infrastructure plays you don't see in headlines, but they matter enormously over 3-5 year horizons. (TechCrunch)

The AI Protocol That's Actually Connecting Everything Just Got Easier to Use. MCP — Model Context Protocol, the standard that lets AI assistants connect to external tools and data sources — has received a significant overhaul. The new version takes a looser, "stateless" approach to session management on the server side, making it far simpler for developers to integrate. Think of it as the USB-C of AI: a common connector that means you don't need a different adapter for every device. The harder MCP becomes to ignore, the more it becomes a genuine platform play — and that's why every major AI lab is paying close attention. (TechCrunch)

OpenAI Is Scared of Open-Weight Models — And That's Rational. A growing chorus in Washington is debating whether to restrict Chinese-made open-weight LLMs, and OpenAI has been unusually vocal in supporting restrictions. The concern is legitimate on its face: an open model that matches GPT-4 capability, downloadable and runnable locally without oversight, is a genuine national security consideration. But the deeper dynamic is competitive. OpenAI's business model depends on API access as the primary revenue engine. A world where powerful open-weight models run cheaply on your own hardware is a world where OpenAI becomes optional. The national security framing and the competitive interest align neatly — which is worth noting when evaluating the policy arguments. (TechCrunch)

Trump's AI Czar Resigned — Again. The director of the Center for AI Standards and Innovation (CAISI), the federal AI role that David Sacks previously held before his own resignation, has now also left the post. The position has become a revolving door since its creation. CAISI was meant to coordinate federal AI policy, but the repeated turnover suggests the role lacks the authority or resources to actually move the needle. Bureaucratic positions without budget teeth tend to attract idealists and repel pragmatists — and Washington runs on both. (TechCrunch)

Gritt Emerges From Stealth With \$34 Million to Put Robots on Solar Construction Sites. The construction robotics startup is targeting the hardest, most dangerous tasks on solar farm builds — precisely the kind of repetitive, physically demanding work that drives up labor costs and slows deployment. The \$34 million seed round is sizable for a stealth-stage hardware company, reflecting investor appetite for automation that directly reduces the cost of energy infrastructure. The logic: solar costs have fallen dramatically in hardware, but installation labor hasn't. Robots that can work nights, weekends, and in hazardous conditions without cutting corners are a natural answer. (TechCrunch)

Firefighting Drones Are Getting Serious Funding as Wildfire Season Becomes Year-Round. California and the XPRIZE foundation are backing a major competition to develop autonomous drones capable of stopping wildfires before they become megafires. The effort reflects a grim new reality: wildfire season in the western US now effectively runs 10-11 months per year. Current firefighting drones are limited by regulation and battery life; the prize is targeting systems that can operate in the critical first-hour window when a fire is still small enough to contain. (Ars Technica)

FINANCIAL & MARKETS

Stock markets, crypto, economic indicators, and trading

Robinhood Chain Hits \$430 Million in TVL in Under Three Weeks. Robinhood's Layer-2 chain has amassed \$431 million in total value locked since launch, with 250,000+ daily active users. The numbers are genuinely impressive for a DeFi product from a traditional finance incumbent. But there's a catch buried in the fine print: 80% of the \$9 billion in DEX volume on the chain comes from memecoins — the kind of speculative trading that's entertaining but structurally fragile. FalconX, the institutional crypto exchange, put out research noting that RWAs (real-world assets) are the actual differentiator for sustainable chain growth. Memecoins are the traffic; RWA integration is the business model. (The Block)

CoinShares Launches UCITS Platform to Bring Crypto Products to Europe's \$30 Trillion Institutional Market. Europe's UCITS (Undertakings for Collective Investment in Transferable Securities) framework is the dominant structure for regulated investment products on the continent — \$30 trillion in assets under management. CoinShares just launched a platform targeting this market with a Bitcoin Mining ETF, giving European institutional investors regulated exposure to crypto mining revenue for the first time. This is a big structural unlock: Europe's pension funds and wealth managers have been largely locked out of direct crypto exposure by compliance frameworks that predate digital assets. CoinShares is building the on-ramp. (The Block)

London Stock Exchange Wants to Trade Overnight. The LSE is exploring an overnight trading venue as traditional exchanges face pressure from 24/7 crypto platforms that never close. The move reflects a structural question that's been building for years: why should equity markets stop when crypto markets don't? Extending hours isn't trivial — settlement systems, clearing houses, and market maker participation all need to follow. But the direction of travel is clear: if Robinhood Chain can run 24/7 with \$430M in TVL, the legacy exchanges will eventually have to answer the question. (The Block)

SEC Charges \$22 Million Crypto Mining Fraud. The Securities and Exchange Commission filed charges against a Florida man and his company for allegedly raising \$22 million from 380+ investors through a fraudulent crypto asset mining scheme. The pitch was straightforward: invest in our mining operation, earn guaranteed returns. The reality: there was no mining operation, or at least not one generating the returns being paid out. This is a Ponzi structure wearing a cryptoMining hat — same story, new vocabulary. (The Block)

Trump Agrees to Ethics Provision as Crypto Bill Nears Senate Vote. A crypto regulatory bill that has been inching through Congress just got a meaningful boost: President Trump agreed to include ethics language around his family's financial interests in digital assets. The provision doesn't eliminate conflicts — Trump's involvement in crypto businesses through World Liberty Financial remains an open question — but it signals willingness to move the legislation forward. A Senate vote could come within weeks, which would be the most significant US crypto legislation since the FITARA amendments of the previous cycle. (The Block)

Kalshi's Sports Prediction Markets Blocked in Washington State. A Washington state court granted a preliminary injunction against Kalshi, blocking its sports prediction markets on the grounds that they constitute illegal gambling under state law. The ruling is a setback for prediction markets that had been gaining regulatory ground in other states. Kalshi had argued that its markets were financial instruments providing real informational value — not gambling devices. The court disagreed, at least under Washington's specific gambling statute. The case is likely headed for appeal, where the broader question of whether prediction markets constitute gambling will finally get federal scrutiny. (The Block)

Judge Blocks Paramount's \$111 Billion Purchase of Warner Bros. A federal judge granted a restraining order halting Paramount's \$111 billion acquisition of Warner Bros., saying the deal "likely to violate antitrust laws." The ruling is a significant win for state attorneys general who sued to block the merger, arguing it would concentrate too much of the streaming and studio market in a single entity. The deal would have created a company controlling Paramount+, HBO Max, and a combined theatrical slate — the kind of scale that regulators are increasingly skeptical of in the streaming era. (Ars Technica)

Space Force Wants to Spend \$30 Billion on Rocket Launches. The US Space Force has issued a formal request for proposals to purchase up to \$30 billion in rocket launch services over the coming decade — the largest government commercial space commitment in history. The solicitation covers both■■■■ (national security) and civil space missions, and it's designed to ensure the US has guaranteed access to multiple launch providers rather than depending on a single vendor. The big winners from this pipeline: SpaceX (already dominant), with potential slots for Blue Origin, Rocket Lab, and emerging heavy-lift players. (Ars Technica)

BRIEFLY

◀ **AliExpress fined \$625 million** by the EU for failing to remove unsafe toys and dangerous cosmetics from its platform — the largest DSA fine yet issued. (Ars Technica)

◀ **Colossal Biosciences**, the de-extinction startup (think: bringing back the woolly mammoth), is reportedly in talks to raise new capital at a \$20-30 billion valuation, which would be a dramatic jump from its previous valuation. (TechCrunch)

◀ **X rebuilt its Android app** from the ground up over the past year and has now relaunched it globally. The old app had accumulated years of technical debt that made performance fixes nearly impossible. (TechCrunch)

THE TAKEAWAY

The most important story this Tuesday isn't a single headline — it's the convergence of forces reshaping how AI and capital markets interact. Anthropic's \$1.5B settlement is a milestone, but it doesn't answer the harder question: what does the AI industry look like when the legal theory behind training data is actually resolved? Until that question gets answered, every AI company's balance sheet carries latent liability.

On the market side, the real signal is institutional adoption of crypto infrastructure moving faster than the regulatory frameworks designed to contain it. CoinShares opening Europe's \$30T UCITS market to Bitcoin mining exposure, LSE exploring 24/7 trading, Kalshi getting blocked in Washington — these are the grinding, unglamorous steps of a market structure being rebuilt in real time. The headlinegrabbers get the attention; the infrastructure changes determine who wins the next decade.

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